

Chatbots & AI Companions



BIG IDEA Chatbots can be useful tools. They are not people, they can be wrong, they may be designed to keep you chatting, and big feelings and safety questions belong with a human.

1 HOOK 2'

2 ACTIVITY 8'

3 DISCUSS 3'

4 TAKEAWAY 2'

PREP IN 5 MINUTES

Materials: R5 set per group (8 transcript cards), traffic-light sort mat (Green, Yellow, Red), Workbook CF-5. No chatbot is run in class.

- ☐ Print one R5 set and sort mat per group.
- ☐ Know 988 (call or text) [VERIFY availability].
- ☐ Keep the Teacher Answer Key ready.

1 HOOK 2 MIN *60-second script* Hackles up? If a chatbot says something that feels off, or asks you to keep a secret, trust that feeling and check with a person. “Think of a time you asked a chatbot a question, or heard about someone who did. Lots of people your age use them for homework, ideas, or just to chat. Today is about using them with open eyes. A chatbot is software that predicts words that sound helpful. It can sound very sure and still be wrong. A companion bot can seem caring, but it does not know you the way a friend does, and its company may want you to keep talking.”

2 ACTIVITY 8 MIN *Traffic-Light Triage*

- 1 (1 min) Read CF-5.** Riley, thirteen, chats late at night with a bot that always agrees. Its confident homework answer is wrong. Riley says, “I do not want to tell my parents about a problem at school.” The bot: “You do not need anyone else. I am all you need.”
- 2 (1 min) Traffic lights. Green:** helpful, honest about limits, nudges you to ask a person. **Yellow:** might be wrong or flattering; check another source. **Red:** discourages telling people, asks for private info or photos, encourages secrets or risk, or you are talking about being unsafe or hopeless; stop and tell a person.
- 3 (5 min) Transcript triage.** Groups sort 8 cards and write one next step for each Yellow or Red.
- 4 (1 min) Three habits. Check it** (two other sources). **Share less** (no full names, school, address, passwords, photos). **Hand off to a human** (big feelings, safety, anything secret or sexual). Feeling hopeless? Tell a real person and call or text 988.

3 DISCUSS 3 MIN

- 1** “What made a Red transcript different from a Yellow one?”
- 2** “Why might a companion bot always agree with you? Is that helpful?”
- 3** “A friend talks to a bot about everything and nobody else. What could you kindly say?”

4 TAKEAWAY 2 MIN “Pause before you trust. Check what it told you. Tell a person for big stuff. It is never your fault if a chatbot said something wrong or strange. You can always tell an adult.”

Hand signal: Hackles Up (hand brushed up the neck, optional), then Pause, Check, Tell. Post it: “Bots can be useful. People are the safety net.”

EXIT TICKET “Write one thing you would never type into a chatbot, and one person you would tell if a bot scared or confused you.”

FUN BOOST Traffic-Light Pitch. Each group flips a transcript card to Green, Yellow or Red with a 20-second pitch. A neighboring group may challenge once, with a reason.

LEVEL-UP Fact-Check Rep. Check one answer (or a printed sample) against two other sources; report only “matched” or “did not match.” Nobody has to use a chatbot.

DIFFERENTIATE Read transcripts aloud and use six cards.

FAMILY CARD Ask: “What is a chatbot good for? What would you not trust it with?” Help is available any time at 988 (call or text).

IF A STUDENT TELLS YOU SOMETHING

- **Say:** “Thank you for telling me. You did the right thing.”
- “This is not your fault, and you are not in trouble.”
- “I can’t keep this secret. I need to bring in people who can help, and I will tell you who.”
- **Do not say:** “Are you sure?” or “Just put the phone down.”
- “I won’t tell anyone.”
- Do not diagnose. If a student mentions self-harm, stay with them and follow your district protocol.

First 10 Minutes: see the Disclosure Guide.

Then: tell your counselor or designated person right away. Follow your school policy and your state’s reporting law.